



AN ANTI-AMERICAN mural near the former U.S. Embassy in Tehran depicts Iran-U.S. peace negotiations. ATTA KENARE AFP/Getty Images

U.S., Iran hold rare direct talks in Pakistan

BY MUNIR AHMED, SAM METZ, E. EDUARDO CASTILLO AND SAMY MAGDY

ISLAMABAD, Pakistan — The United States and Iran began face-to-face negotiations Saturday in Pakistan, days after a fragile, two-week ceasefire was announced, as the war that has killed thousands of people and shaken global markets entered its seventh week.

The White House confirmed the direct nature of the talks, a rare instance of high-level U.S. government engagement with the Iranian government, and said they were ongoing as of 10 p.m. local time.

Meanwhile, the U.S. military said two destroyers transited the Iran-gripped Strait of Hormuz ahead of mine-clearing work, a first since the war began. Iran's state media, however, earlier said Iran forced a U.S. military ship attempting to cross the strait to turn around.

The U.S. delegation led by Vice President JD Vance and the Iranian one led by Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf were discussing with Pakistan how to advance the ceasefire already threatened by deep disagreements and Israel's continued attacks against the Iranian-backed Hezbollah in Lebanon, whose Health Ministry said the death toll has surpassed 2,000.

Since the Islamic Revolution in Iran in 1979, the most direct U.S. contact had been in September 2013 when President Obama called newly elected President

[See Talks, A4]

FALLING POPULATION IMPERILS L.A. COUNTY

The loss, from fewer immigrants, low birth rates, moves to other states, could 'haunt us for decades'

BY JENNY JARVIE

Long the epicenter of population growth in the United States, Los Angeles is slowly losing its people because of a series of demographic shifts that experts say could have profound implications for the county if trends continue.

High housing prices have led a growing number of residents to leave the region for more affordable parts of the country. Immigration — long a pipeline for population growth — has ebbed significantly under a federal crackdown. A rapidly aging population is adding to the concern over how these declines will affect the local economy.

"We've been depending on immigrants all along to sort of backfill our losses. As people move outward, they're replaced by newcomers," said Dowell Myers, a professor of urban planning and demography at USC. "If we had a continued drop in immigration for five years, it would be a major crisis. You can handle one or two years, but as long as the domestic migration is going out, you kind of need to replace those workers with somebody."

New data from the Census Bureau show

L.A. County lost approximately 54,000 people from July 2024 to July 2025, the largest numeric population decline in the nation.

A major factor in 2025, unlike previous years, was a sharp drop in net international migration. As the Trump administration launched an aggressive clampdown on immigration, L.A. County saw the number of new residents coming from abroad plummet from 92,000 people in 2024 to 29,000 in 2025.

More people also continued to move out to other parts of the U.S. than move in. L.A. County had a net loss of 105,000 residents because of domestic migration in 2025, a slight increase from the previous year when the county lost 99,629.

The upshot is Los Angeles, one of the most dynamic boom towns in U.S. history, has led the nation in numeric population loss for all but one of the last eight years. Demographers and regional planners say the slow but persistent decline raises urgent long-term questions about the future of L.A.'s workforce, social services and

[See Population, A11]

L.A. hot sauce is even hotter

Tapatío has new owners and expansion plans as Ozempic alters flavor cravings.

BY ITZEL LUNA

For 55 years, the family behind Tapatío has refused to even write down the recipe for Los Angeles' iconic hot sauce, passing its secret formula for success only from lip to ear in closed rooms.

The Saavedra family put the ingredients on paper for the first time earlier this year as they sold the beloved brand to backers who plan to make their salsa picante

even bigger beyond California's borders. It is a weight off the shoulders of Luis Saavedra, the founder's son and one of the few people who knew the recipe.

"We didn't want anyone to know what we were using," he told The Times in an interview at Tapatío's factory in Vernon. "That always scared my sisters, because what if something happens?"

Demand for hot sauces had taken off for unexpected reasons just as the Saavedras were looking to sell. The millions of people on Ozempic and other powerful weight-loss drugs often have cravings for more flavor. The values of some sauce companies have skyrocketed.

Bachan's, a Japanese barbecue sauce brand, was acquired in February for \$400 million.

While the Dallas private investment firm that bought Tapatío, Highlander Partners, wouldn't share the terms of the deal, the company's new chairman, Jeff Partridge, said it hopes to capitalize on the growing appetite for more heat to splash on proteins.

"Whether it's GLP-1 or desire for proteins, Tapatío and hot sauces enhance that experience," he said. "Consumers are increasingly seeking flavors."

Red peppers drive Tapatío's taste, though the company won't share which ex-

[See Tapatío, A14]

Pressure grows for Swalwell to exit the race

His gubernatorial campaign collapses with abuse claims, new criminal inquiry.

BY MELODY GUTIERREZ, DAKOTA SMITH, NICOLE NIXON AND SEEMA MEHTA

SACRAMENTO — The fallout over allegations against Rep. Eric Swalwell grew Saturday as his fellow gubernatorial candidates found themselves in a re-vamped race and Democrats faced an uncomfortable test on how to respond to the accusations of sexual misconduct against the congressman.

Within hours of the accusations against Swalwell being made public, the Northern California congressman's campaign began to unravel and a chorus of top Democrats urged him to drop out. Staff members resigned, his fundraising website went offline and allies moved quickly to distance themselves from a candidate who had been gaining momentum as a front-runner in the race to lead the Golden State.

The repercussions extended beyond Swalwell's campaign for governor. The Manhattan district attorney's office opened an investigation into sexual assault allegations against Swalwell by a former staffer and issued a statement Saturday that urged "survivors and

anyone with knowledge of these allegations to contact our Special Victims Division." A spokesperson for the Alameda County district attorney's office on Saturday said the office was evaluating "whether any alleged criminal conduct occurred" in the Bay Area agency's jurisdiction.

Rep. Anna Paulina Luna (R-Fla.) posted a video on X saying that she plans to force a House vote next week to expel Swalwell.

Swalwell has denied the allegations, calling them "flat [out] false."

The upheaval has created an opening for lesser-known contenders to gain traction just as voters are beginning to turn their attention to the race — a spotlight now intensified by the controversy.

The speed and severity of the response underscores how quickly political support can erode — and reflects a broader shift in how such allegations are handled in the post-#MeToo era, which has been intensified by the scrutiny surrounding the late financier and convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.

"Ask any woman staffer over the age of 45 what her experience was like, and this was a fairly prevalent sort of situation," said Elizabeth Ashford, a veteran Democratic strategist. "It was allowed. I really think it shows a lot of growth on the part of political professionalism, that these things are taken

[See Swalwell, A8]



RONALDO BOLAÑOS Los Angeles Times

REP. ERIC Swalwell (D-Dublin) has ignored calls to leave the governor's race and resign from Congress.

'Wheels are falling off the bus': Parents fret as strike looms

BY HAILEY BRANSON-POTTS, GARY CORONADO AND NICOLE MACIAS GARIBAY

For one group of moms, the threatened Los Angeles Unified School District strike that would shutter campuses this week is provoking outright fear.

"I don't know what I will do," one woman said in Spanish on Wednesday afternoon, crying.

She is a street vendor from East Hollywood who barely makes ends meet in this expensive city. She is a single mom to a 14- and a 17-year old. And she is an undocumented immigrant.

Her children depend on school meals. But she likely wouldn't go to district-organized food distribution centers because she is terrified that immigration agents will target the sites.

"I pray to God that the school district and the teachers come to an agreement so the strike doesn't happen," said another mother, who also works as an East Hollywood street vendor. "We don't have a voice or vote on this deci-

sion, and the kids are the most affected."

The historic LAUSD employee walkout — which for the first time would involve three major unions representing teachers, most non-teaching staff and school administrators, including principals — is set to begin Tuesday if the unions do not reach agreements.

Families of the district's more than 390,000 students are reeling with the prospect of life routines thrown into uncertainty. They are scrambling for daycare, worrying about food, fretting about their ability to work.

On Thursday, the district said on its website that officials continue to meet with union leaders and are "committed to reaching agreements." It posted lists of food distribution sites and community-based "child supervision" sites that could take in a limited number of children.

As both sides prepare for a potential strike, many parents are voicing strong support for the unions' goals of providing better pay for educators, administrators and school staff.

[See L.A. Unified, A9]



LACMA's art of reinvention

A look at the museum's radical new building and its essential works, plus a guide to the campus. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

Self-deportation policy rejected

Judge tells U.S. to halt "blatantly coercive" language with immigrant kids. NATION, A7

Feldstein Soto loses support

Union pulls backing of city attorney after data breach exposes LAPD files. CALIFORNIA, B1

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Weather

Periods of rain. L.A. Basin: 70/52. B8



A WEEKEND FOR BOOK LOVERS

Time to get ready for the Festival of Books with a guide to events, plus our 101 best book club picks. More at latimes.com/books and latimes.com/fob. SECTIONS S,T



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times